the drizzle, a fact that was brought to my attention by one of my team-mates. The more the moisture, the more it was expected to favour the South African fast bowlers. I remember telling my team-mate that such things don't matter and it all evens out in the end.

This reminded me of something that had happened in Melbourne in December 2003. On the last day of the Test match, with Australia needing 97 runs to win, there was a delay to the start of play despite conditions apparently being perfect. The reason was that the pitch had been tampered with by the groundsmen, in clear violation of the rules. At the end of day four, there was a big crack in the pitch as a result of the wear and tear, and balls landing in the crack could have done anything. To our surprise, the groundsmen had filled up the crack before the start of play on day five, incurring the umpires' wrath. The umpires spotted it because the repaired area had not fully dried out and was a different colour from the rest of the wicket. The umpires had to instruct the groundsmen to undo the repair and restore the pitch to its original condition.

Durban was a low-scoring Test match but no less exciting for that. Zaheer came back to lead our attack and both he and Bhajji bowled brilliantly after we had made a modest 205 in our first innings. They combined well to finish South Africa off for just 131 in their first innings and were aided by some brilliant catching behind the wickets. Rahul picked up his 200th catch in this match when he caught Dale Steyn off Bhajji at slip. It was one of Rahul's best catches and he had to dive full length to his left and pick it up almost from behind the wicketkeeper. We celebrated the dismissal in the knowledge that the match was gradually turning in our favour.

In our second innings, it was another VVS Laxman special that got us out of trouble. He showed class in his innings of 96 and gave us a lead of over 300 to defend in the final innings. Laxman batted brilliantly with the tail, which was something he was a master at in the latter stages of his career. He was always unflustered and exuded a sense of calm which rubbed off on the other batsmen.

It was now up to Zaheer, Ishant, Sreesanth and Bhajji to finish the job and level the series. They did it in some style. South Africa were never allowed to get away and our bowlers sent down some unplayable deliveries. Sreesanth's ball to Kallis that jumped from short of a length and left him in no position to do anything was the best of the match.